

Gently into the Night

The topsy-turvy world of Kashmir is recreated through the eyes of a young boy whose father leaves his family to join the jihad



WEED
by PARO ANAND
IndiaInk
Price: Rs 195
Pages: 142

■ By Brinda Bose

Weed is a novella that churns and seethes, simmers and smoulders. Its narrator is a young Kashmiri boy Umer, whose ordinary childhood is one day shot to pieces when his father sneaks away in the dead of the night to join the jihad. Its author is Paro Anand, who has written an impressive 17 books for children and young adults, and it is a "follow-up" to her earlier novel on Kashmir, *No Guns at My Son's Funeral*. *Weed* may well be one of the simplest tales ever written about one of the most complex of human predicaments—the psychology of jihadis/*atankvadis* at the heart of political unrest in Kashmir—but it is also one that will leave every reader, young or old, shaken, stirred and saddened.

Umer and Umed's precious "Abbu" deserted them after a final showdown with their mother, their "Ammi jaan" who was as recklessly proud of her own honesty, her honour and her beliefs as she was possessive of her

young sons. Even as we try not to judge the man who abandoned his family for his politics, we share every moment of his wife's heartache and anxiety, and helplessly watch the boys being stifled in the cocoon their mother tries to secure ever more tightly around them as they grow. Umer, who shows early signs of defiance when he attempts to follow his father into the "colddark" of the curfew-ravaged night that he disappeared into, ironically turns out to be the son who finally stays back with his mother. His baby brother, who hid under the bed and wailed when strangers came, is the one who determinedly leaves home in search of the father he hardly remembers and a future that is uncertain and unsafe.

Though it is not as if Umer and his mother's lives are placidly secure either. Bereft not merely of a husband

and a father but also of its sole breadwinner, the household is hard put to keep body and soul together and ticking, even as it reels under shadows of suspicion from the state, from non-governmental bodies and the neighbourhood. In one of the novella's most moving sections, Umer and his Ammi approach an organisation that "helped what they called the half-widowed and the half-orphaned". They discover that they now have a new identity: "We had a title now. A name to call our sadness by. Half. Those whose husbands had disappeared... taken by the army or by separatists. Or what?"

It is the "Or what?", the unanswered questions brooding over Umer's father's melt-into-the-night disappearance that shroud Anand's novella like a dull fog: as "colddark", as eerily silent, but as full of unspeakable terrors as that nocturnal peregrination that precipitates one family's freefall into poverty and complete despair. She captures, with rare piquancy, a young boy's perspective, how the topsy-turvy world of Kashmiri insurgency generates confusion and conspiracy, revolution and self-sacrifice, terror, tribulation and death. Anand is impressively adept at (re)creating young language, partly by employing the pointillistic style, recording minutiae registered by a teenage mind, tossing single-word sentences and short phrases together in boyish breathlessness. Indeed, it is a rare privilege to be invited to share this youthful gaze upon such a grim world. ■

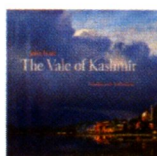


NEW RELEASES



THE CHARISMATIC LEADER: QAUID-I-AZAM MOHAMMAD ALI JINNAH AND THE CREATION OF PAKISTAN
by SIKANDAR HAYAT
Oxford (Karachi)
Price: Rs 955; Pages: 386

The book charts the life of Jinnah, the man India considers responsible for the Partition. Hayat provides a detailed analysis of Jinnah's "charismatic" leadership, defining and discussing the concept of charisma in the process.



THE VALE OF KASHMIR
by JOHN ISAAC
W.W. Norton
Price: \$65
Pages: 191

The book is a world-renowned photographer's tribute to the land and people of Kashmir. Through his stunning photographs, he celebrates the area's landscape, people and their unique way of life.



OLD DELHI-NEW YORK PERSONAL VIEWS
by C.S.H. JHABVALA
Roli Books
Price: Rs 1,495; Pages: 108

An architect by profession, Jhabvala brings his wholly original and personal views to two cities—Delhi and New York, both of them in their own ways being complex, exciting and paradoxically beautiful.